

Superstore Sales Performance

A Data Visualization & Storytelling Report

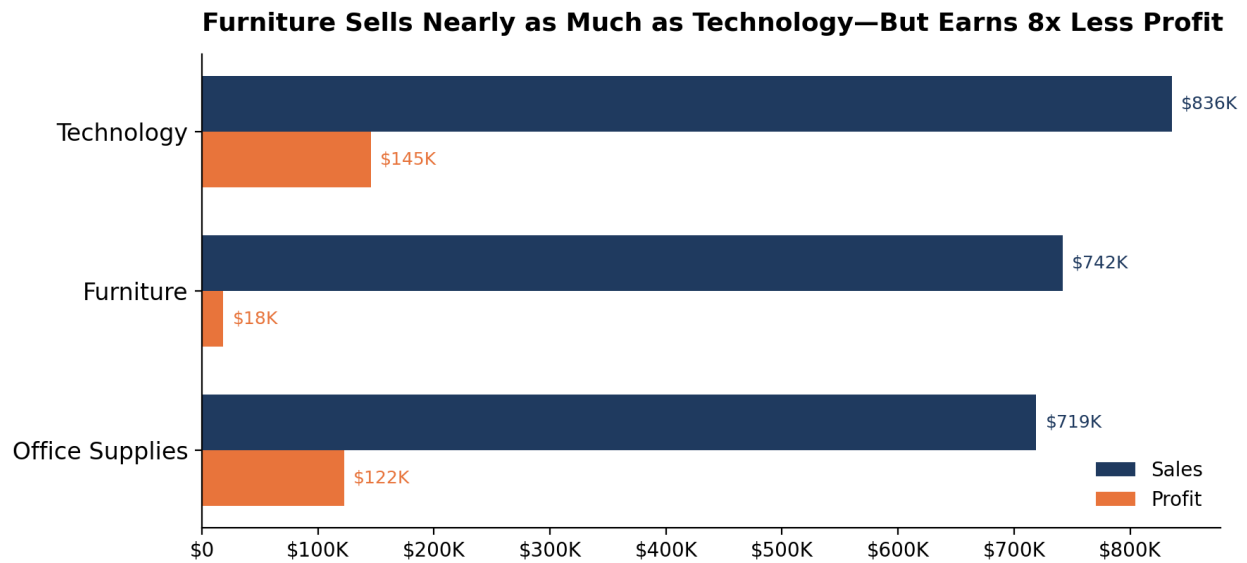
Dataset: Sample Superstore (2014–2017) | 9,994 orders | 3 categories, 17 sub-categories, 4 regions

\$2.30M	\$286K	12.5%	3
Total Sales	Total Profit	Profit Margin	Sub-Categories Losing Money

Prepared for: Data Analyst Internship – Task 2 (DataX Labs)

Objective: Identify what drives sales, where profit is being lost, and what actions leadership should take.

Insight 1: Furniture Is a Volume Trap



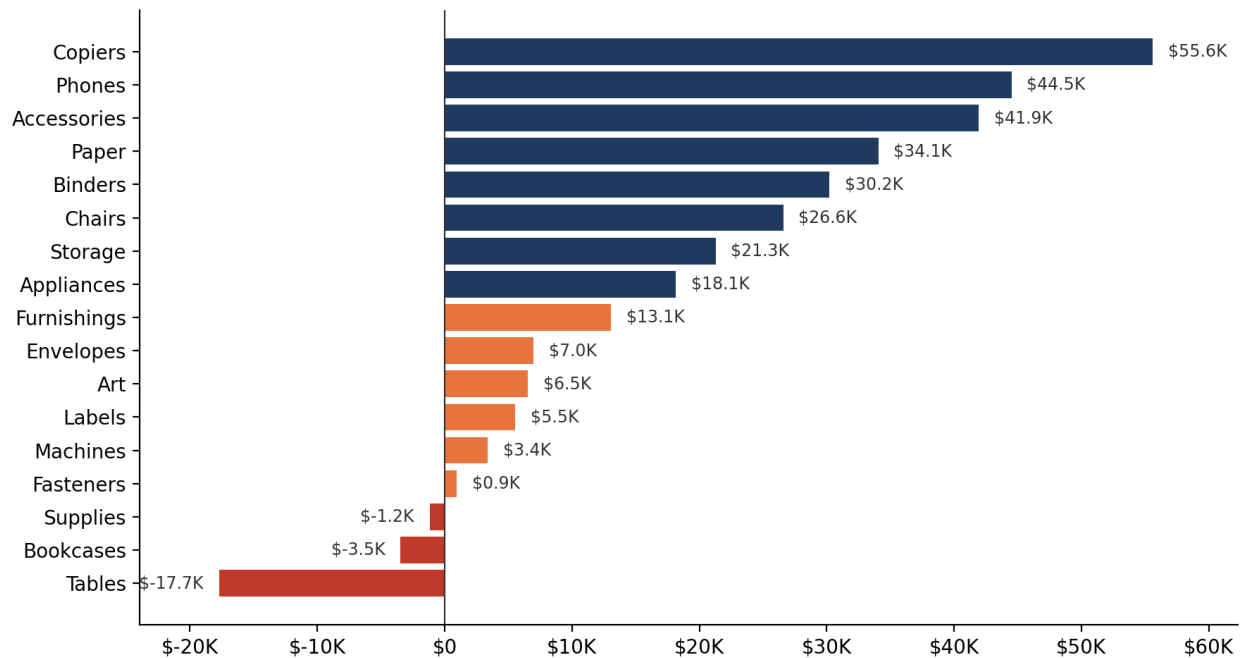
KEY TAKEAWAY

Furniture generates almost as much revenue as Technology (\$742K vs \$836K) but returns only **\$18K in profit — roughly one-eighth** of what Technology earns on similar sales. The category is selling well but not making money.

Why it matters: Growing Furniture sales without fixing its margin problem will grow revenue while barely moving the profit needle. The next chart shows exactly which products are dragging it down.

Insight 2: Three Sub-Categories Are Losing Money

Tables, Bookcases & Supplies Are Losing Money

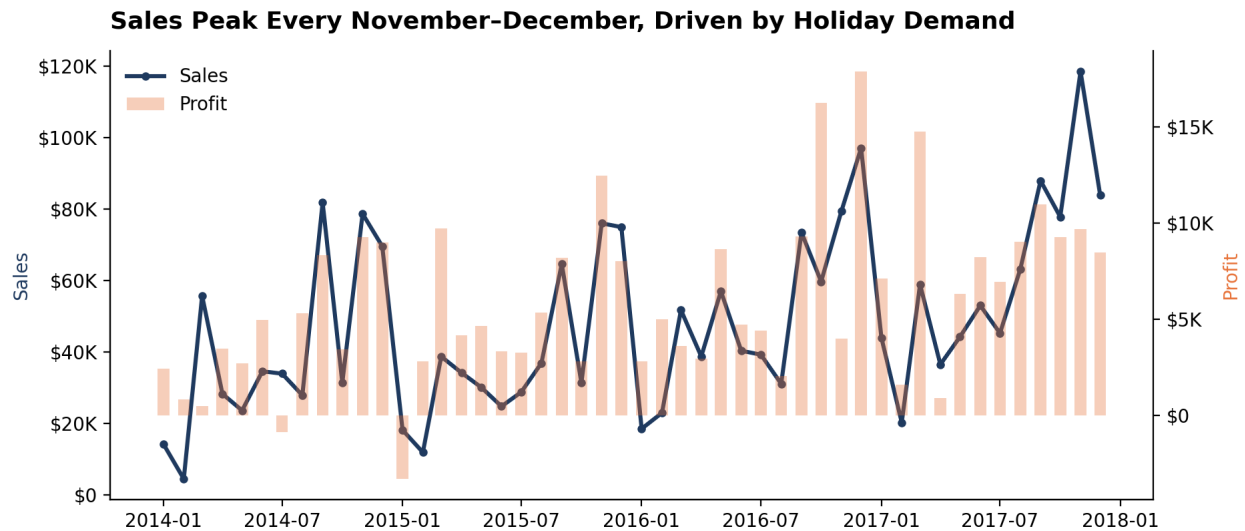


KEY TAKEAWAY

Tables (-\$17.7K), Bookcases (-\$3.5K) and Supplies (-\$1.2K) are the only sub-categories that lose money overall. Tables alone wipes out more profit than Copiers — the top performer — earns in a third of its sales volume.

Why it matters: Copiers, Phones and Accessories are the real profit engines. Fixing or de-prioritizing Tables would have an outsized impact on overall margin.

Insight 3: Sales Are Highly Seasonal

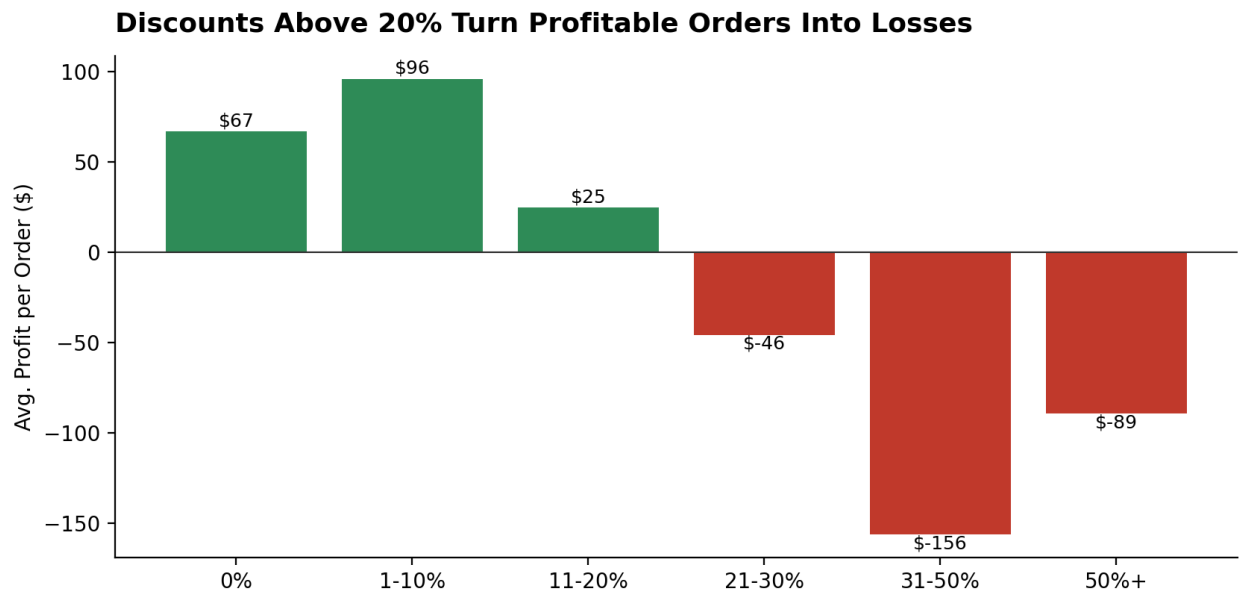


KEY TAKEAWAY

Sales climb steadily every year and **spike every November–December**, consistent with holiday and year-end corporate buying. 2017 closed as the strongest year in the dataset.

Why it matters: Inventory, staffing and marketing budgets should be weighted toward Q4. Profit doesn't always track sales one-to-one — some high-sales months (e.g. Nov 2016) show comparatively weaker profit, hinting at heavier discounting during peak season.

Insight 4: Heavy Discounting Destroys Profit

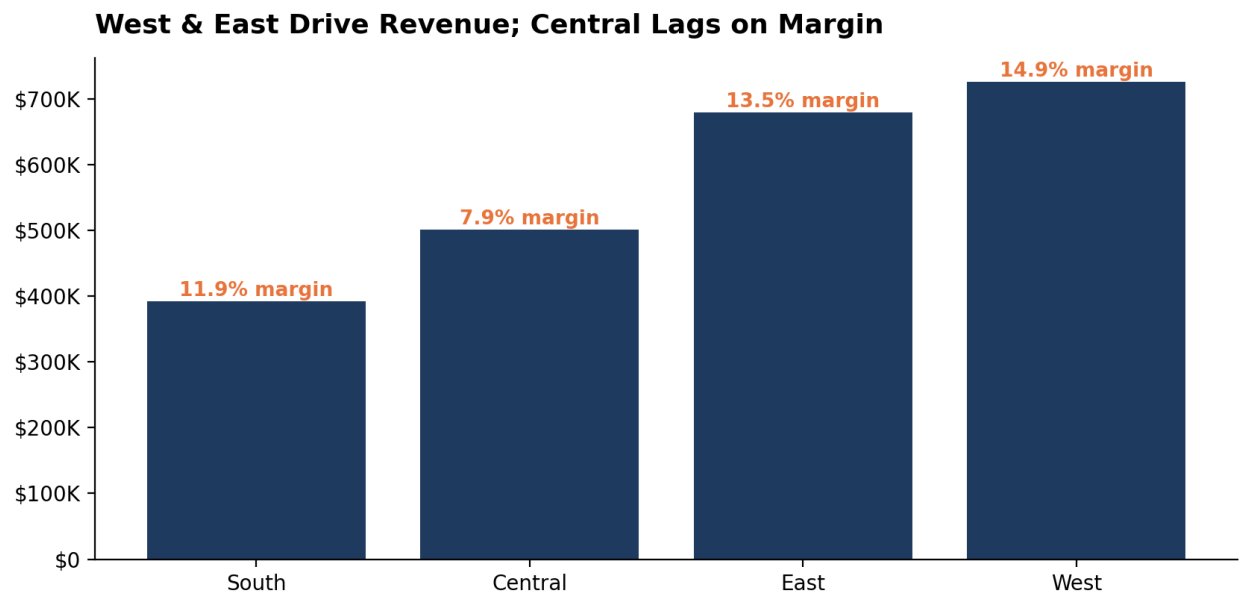


KEY TAKEAWAY

Orders discounted 20% or less stay profitable — averaging **\$25–\$96 profit per order**. Once discounts exceed 20%, average profit per order turns **negative**, bottoming out at **-\$156 per order** in the 31–50% discount range.

Why it matters: This is the clearest lever in the dataset. Capping discounts at 20%, especially on Tables and Bookcases, would directly convert losses into profit.

Insight 5: West & East Lead, Central Underperforms



KEY TAKEAWAY

The West region leads in both sales (\$725K) and healthy margin (14.9%). Central has the lowest sales **and** the thinnest margin (7.9%), while East and South sit in between.

Why it matters: Central's underperformance on both volume and margin makes it the region most worth investigating — whether the cause is local discounting practices, product mix, or logistics costs.

Summary Storyboard: The Story in 5 Beats

1. Strong top line

Sales grew steadily from 2014–2017, totaling \$2.30M, with a reliable Nov–Dec seasonal peak.

2. Thin overall margin

Despite strong sales, the company keeps only 12.5% as profit (\$286K) — Furniture is the main drag.

3. A few products cause most of the pain

Tables, Bookcases and Supplies are net loss-makers; Tables alone costs \$17.7K.

4. Discounting is the mechanism

Profit turns negative once discounts pass 20% — this explains much of the loss in Furniture and Tables.

5. Central region needs attention

Lowest sales and lowest margin of any region — a candidate for deeper investigation.

Recommended Actions

- Cap discounts at 20% on Furniture, especially Tables and Bookcases.
- Reassess Tables pricing/sourcing — the single biggest source of loss.
- Protect margin during the Nov–Dec peak by controlling discount-driven promotions.
- Double down on Copiers, Phones and Accessories — the highest-margin sub-categories.
- Investigate Central region's cost structure and discounting practices.